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Surviving and thriving: voices from teachers in remote and disadvantaged regions of Vietnam

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ABSTRACT

Teaching in high need areas often requires significant resilience, especially as global education systems are recovering from COVID-19. This study aims to offer some insights into aspects of teacher resilience in areas of greater adversity. We investigated strategies of resilience exhibited by a group of 53 teachers working in the northern mountainous areas of Vietnam. Findings indicate that the teachers experienced tremendous ongoing and unique contextual challenges that kept them from developing professionally. The study finds that the contextual challenges outweighed the available coping resources, resulting in the teachers “surviving not yet thriving”. Resilience strategies used by the teachers were mostly from within themselves (e.g., motivation, teaching passion, enthusiasm, and a sense of purpose) and from their colleagues’ support. There was, however, a substantial lack of financial, practical, emotional and institutional support from schools and local authorities. Implications for teacher resilience intervention and research are discussed.

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Introduction

The OECD 2030 Agenda echoes the needs for building human for a more sustainable world (OECD/EC-JRC, 2021). This call states the importance of enhancing individual resilience capacity, including teacher resilience. Teacher resilience, which is defined as “the developable capacity to rebound or bounce back from adversity, conflict, failure or even positive events” (Luthans, 2002, p. 702), has received growing scholarly attention as many countries struggle with increasing teacher shortages (C. F. Mansfield, 2020). It has also gained much attention over recent decades from researchers, as teaching is a challenging and demanding profession (Beltman et al., 2011; Falk et al., 2022; Fokkens-Bruinsma et al., 2023; Hong, 2012; C. F. Mansfield et al., 2016). Moreover, the recent COVID-19 literature suggests the mediating role of resilience as a buffer against the emotional distress that teachers experienced during the pandemic (Lacomba-Trejo et al., 2022).

Resilience has been researched widely across different contexts. According to Beltman et al. (2011, p. 185), teacher resilience is defined as “the outcome of a dynamic relationship between

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individual risks and protective factors” which can be contextual or personal. Resilience is also the characteristic of being able to “bounce back” when facing adverse circumstances (Gu & Day, 2007, p. 1302). However, it is not only the capacity to recover from stress, but also the ability to maintain healthy coping mechanisms in stressful situations, as noted by Zautra et al. (2010). Overall, resilience is a dynamic process wherein personal and contextual factors come together (C. Mansfield et al., 2014). This is because personal attributes are not sufficient to predict resilience (Kent & Davis, 2010), and there is a complexity “in reciprocal person-environment interactions” (Ungar, 2012, p. 14). The emphasis on both personal and contextual contributions to resilience suggests the complex and multidimensional characteristics of the construct. Notably, Beltman’s work in 2020 highlights resilience as a collective responsibility and construct, which links to the implications for policy changes suggested in the present study.

In general, the role that teacher resilience plays in educational settings is crucial, as it is linked to important educational outcomes including commitment to the profession (Collie & Mansfield, 2022; Lee & Nie, 2014), reduced workplace stress (Chang, 2009) and increased teacher retention (Doney, 2013). Every day, teachers encounter a wide range of stressors, such as school administration, teaching duties and interactions with students and parents, which can potentially lead to emotional exhaustion, burnout and attrition (Gu & Day, 2013). Teacher emotional exhaustion and burnout are linked to negative students’ learning outcomes. For example, according to a study by Arens and Morin in 2016, there is a correlation between teachers’ high level of emotional exhaustion and their students’ lower level of academic performance. Similarly, a case study conducted at a primary school in Germany found a strong correlation between teachers’ emotional burnout and the low test scores of their students (Klusmann et al., 2016).

In times of difficulty and even crisis such as a global pandemic, resilience is what enables teaching professionals to lead the necessary changes and not only survive but also thrive (Beltman et al., 2011; Lacomba-Trejo et al., 2022). Teacher resilience contributes to developing teachers’ sense of self-efficacy, leadership and confidence (Gu & Day, 2007), which greatly impact teachers’ goal setting (Hoy & Spero, 2005) and job satisfaction (Collie et al., 2016; le Cornu, 2009). Teacher resilience also influences many aspects of student learning such as engagement (Shoshani & Eldor, 2016) and academic achievement (Arens & Morin, 2016).

However, despite the rich understanding of resilience in the literature, it is not well understood how teachers across various contexts are able to cope with challenging teaching situations or how resilience compares across countries with vastly different social, economic and cultural contexts (Beltman, 2020). Examining this area of research is significant because teachers working in rural and remote locations may face challenges and receive support that differs from those in urban environments (Downes & Roberts, 2018).

Specifically, research on teacher resilience in Asian cultures is scarce, with most research conducted on Western countries (Beltman et al., 2011). More generally, since the post COVID-19 recovery of education systems worldwide has revealed a need for policy changes to enhance educators’ responsiveness and resilience during extraordinary circumstances (OECD, 2020b), more studies about teacher resilience in high adversity situations are needed. Understanding teacher resilience across different contexts is thus necessary for developing strategies to better support all teachers.

The context of Vietnam

Education in the northern mountainous regions of Vietnam presents significant challenges including geographical isolation, low student literacy, limited access to resources, shortage of qualified teachers, and a lack of employment opportunities (ISEE and CARE, 2011; Ngo et al., 2017; Tran et al., 2016). These densely populated regions of about 6.7 million people, most of whom are of ethnic minority and low socioeconomic status (Tran et al., 2016), create problematic working conditions for teachers. Before the global pandemic, teacher attrition rates were already high. In Vietnam, one in ten teachers have reported their intention of quitting the profession (OECD, 2020b).

A study by Ngo and colleagues (2017) with 42 EFL primary teachers in a mountainous province finds that teachers in remote areas encounter several challenges. These include poor teaching conditions, lack of support from the government and community, limited professional opportunities, and ethnic minority students' limited language proficiency. Other studies indicate that various challenges that teachers face lead to them providing insufficient support to students (Bui & Nguyen, 2016; D. C. Nguyen et al., 2014).

Teachers in disadvantaged areas often fail to offer responsive teaching approaches (Bui & Nguyen, 2016; H. T. M. Nguyen & Bui, 2016) and an appropriate curriculum to meet the students' needs and learning styles (V. H. Nguyen & Hamid, 2015). Moreover, Vietnamese teachers' responsiveness to student-centred learning and a digitalized curriculum have been important educational concerns during and since COVID-19 (Vu et al., 2021). Therefore, the present investigation into teacher resilience aims to contribute to the retention of teachers in high -adversity regions and to enhance the quality of teachers and teaching.

Resilience strategies

As teachers face stressors from both individual and contextual factors, an examination of the strategies they employ should incorporate both personal and contextual resources. Use of strategies is indeed the process by which teachers employ personal and contextual resources to thrive professionally amid the challenging times (Castro et al., 2010). Several studies have identified strategies that promote teacher resilience. Castro and colleagues (2010, p. 624) conducted a study on new teachers' resilience strategies in high need schools, finding four main strategies across all participants: "help-seeking, problem-solving, managing difficult relationships, and seeking rejuvenation". In line with these strategies, other research has found specific skills associated with teacher resilience such as effective classroom practices, strong interpersonal skills, and commitment to professional development (Tait, 2008). Furthermore, personal attributes such as intrinsic motivation, high teaching self-efficacy, optimism and flexibility, hope and persistence are found to play a critical role in teacher resilience (C. F. Mansfield et al., 2012; Tan & Soo, 2022). Finally, protective environmental factors such as mentoring, and support from family, friends, colleagues and schools are shown to be necessary to promote teacher resilience (C. F. Mansfield et al., 2012). As many researchers have investigated teachers' resilience strategies and presented various findings, an overarching framework has been found to be necessary to encompass and connect resilience strategies. A "four-dimensional framework of teacher resilience" (C. F. Mansfield et al., 2012, p. 362) serves this purpose by integrating different dimensions of resilience strategies: professional, emotional, social, and motivational.

This framework is based on Kumpfer's framework for resilience research (1999) which consists of five dimensions: cognitive, emotional, social, physical, and spiritual/motivational (C. F. Mansfield et al., 2012). Within the new framework, C. F. Mansfield et al. (2012) removed the physical dimension and changed the cognitive dimension into professional, as this is more relevant and specific to the teaching profession. The framework is empirically derived and describes four distinct dimensions of teacher resilience (Helker et al., 2018), as well as enabling overlaps in teacher resilience strategies. The present study uses the "four dimensional framework of teacher resilience" (C. F. Mansfield et al., 2012, p. 362) as a conceptual lens due to its comprehensive integration of varied resilience strategies and resources. Drawing upon Mansfield and colleagues' (2012) framework, some recent studies have further developed theoretical constructs and measurement models in the sphere of teacher resilience. For example, Liu and Chu (2022) proposed a tri-factorial construct of EFL teacher resilience in the Chinese context involving tenacity, optimism, and coping style. The coping style component echoes Mansfield and colleagues' conception of contextual interactions influencing resilience processes. In addition, Collie and Martin (2017) conducted a quantitative evaluation examining how teachers' perceived autonomy support correlates with adaptability, a factor resonating with dimensions in Mansfield and colleagues' (2012) framework, and their subsequent impacts on teacher

wellbeing and commitment. Such research has extended facets of Mansfield and colleagues' original conceptualization for targeted investigation using quantitative approaches. Meanwhile, our qualitative study employs Mansfield and colleagues' comprehensive model as an overarching lens. The study investigated the following questions:

- (1) What are the challenges the teachers in remote regions of northern Vietnam encounter that may affect their resilience?
- (2) What resilience strategies do they employ?

Methodology

The main aim of this study is to gain an in-depth understanding of phenomena (resilience strategies) within a small group of 53 participant teachers from diverse backgrounds in the northern regions of Vietnam. For that reason, the researchers adopted a qualitative approach and chose a case study methodology for the study. In addition, a case study approach helps to obtain personal perspectives and provide insights into a currently understudied topic: the resilience strategies of Asian teachers (and in particular, Vietnamese teachers, in this study).

Participants

The 53 participants in the present study consist of teachers selected using purposive sampling, which is a "deliberate selection of specific individuals, events, or settings" (Liamputtong, 2013, p. 22), to ensure that rich information and in-depth understanding are obtained during the data collection process. They were also selected as participants based on the following criteria. Firstly, they were teachers during the data collection process and teaching in the disadvantaged regions in Vietnam. Secondly, they agreed to participate in this study as indicated by signed written consent. All participants come from diverse backgrounds. 15% are from the delta areas, while the remainder are local. The 15% of participants from the delta regions had relocated to live and teach long-term in the northern mountainous area sites of this study. The rest were native to the north. While not all originally from the northern villages, the entire sampled population accurately comprises teachers who had settled in the region and currently serve the remote northern communities that align with the study's consistent geographical focus. Half of the participant population belongs to an ethnic minority. These teachers share the same backgrounds as their students. The participants have a wide range of teaching experience, with most having from 4 to 12 years of experience in teaching ethnic minority students. Focus group participants were referred to as "Participants from Focus Group" or "PFG" (e.g., "PFG1" means "Participants from Focus Group 1").

Focus group interviews

The researchers held nine semi-structured focus group interviews, with each group involving four to seven teachers, as small groups of up to seven participants allow for in-depth conversations (Krueger, 2014). For representativeness, each group had at least one early career and one mid-career teacher. Every interview spanned approximately 45 minutes, ensuring each participant had sufficient time to express their perspectives on the research topic, fostering additional clarification and exploration. It was anticipated that group members would largely overcome their own anxiety or shyness about offering their views by hearing other teachers speak about similar experiences, leading to "relatively spontaneous responses from participants as well as producing a fairly high level of participant involvement" (Morgan, 1997, p. 17). The interview questions were crafted based on the framework by C. F. Mansfield et al. (2012) to delve into different dimensions of resilience strategies employed by the participants.

Data analysis

The interviews were conducted in Vietnamese and audio recorded. Afterwards, the focus group recordings were transcribed, translated into English, and coded for emerging themes using NVivo 16 software. Since resilience strategies is the main topic of this study, the researchers then grouped coded data into four categories (Motivational, Social, Emotional, and Professional) using the “four dimensional framework of teacher resilience” by C. F. Mansfield et al. (2012, p. 362). Data not falling into one of the abovementioned categories were also kept for further analysis. Next, the researchers interpreted the data by exploring the links among the contextual challenges, cultural influences and teachers’ resilience strategies, and the connections among different dimensions of resilience strategies. We employed the recommendations regarding focus group interpretation by Krueger (2014). Specifically, we systematically incorporated recommendations on interpreting focus group findings regarding importance of words used, taking context into account, assessing internal consistency, tracking frequency and intensity of comments, noting specificity, judging extensiveness of remarks, extracting the “big picture”, documenting group interactions, analysing individual and group viewpoints, and allowing group effects to permeate interpretations. We documented group interactions evident in the focus group interviews to aid interpretation. Our analysis centred on both individual perspectives and larger group dynamics to uncover potential interpretations. We also emphasized the group effect by allowing insights from the focus group exchanges to shape our understanding.

Results and discussion

Research question 1: what are the challenges the teachers in remote regions of northern Vietnam encounter that may affect their resilience?

The findings identify unique and ongoing contextual challenges that the teachers encountered, namely, a critical lack of basic infrastructures, interactions with the parents and students of the ethnic minority groups, and the substantial lack of financial, institutional, and social support.

Inadequate infrastructure

In this study, the teachers had to deal with a wide range of infrastructure-related challenges, namely, difficult roads, temporary classrooms, and lack of electricity, water, and Internet access. For example, the teachers usually had to travel a long distance which can sometimes take half a day by their own motorbikes to their schools, due to a lack of public transportation. They said that the roads were “narrow” (Participants from Focus group 8, hereafter, PFG8), “steep, uneven and rocky” (PFG5) and “slippery if it is rainy” (PFG6). Transportation was perceived to be a concern: “Teaching in mountainous areas means managing to travel tough roads” (PFG1). All participants in all focus group discussions nodded their heads to show their agreement with other participants’ narratives in this regard.

In addition, certain schools lacked concrete classrooms, instead using bamboo modular structures. This caused inconvenience, with “animals entering and creating unsanitary conditions” (PFG2, 5). This was exemplified by this extract from a focus group interview in which two participants took turns to describe how hard it was for their jobs under such a tough situation where there no electricity. They said that it “hinders students’ doing homework and getting Internet access” (PFG9, 10). Water shortage was another issue, forcing teachers to “walk long distances to fetch water during dry seasons” (PFG7). Infrastructure-related difficulties can consume a significant amount of time and energy and keep teachers from developing professionally (Lock et al., 2012; Sullivan & Johnson, 2012). In addition, the lack of basic Internet access infrastructure is very concerning as the post COVID-19 literature suggests the crucial role of digital tools in helping to maintain effective teaching (Vu et al., 2021). The present study provides ample evidence to confirm that these problems may be

exacerbated in remote areas, adding more challenges for teachers and limiting their resilience capacity (Ellison & Woods, 2020).

Interactions with students and parents

Another category of comments regarding the teachers' challenges is interactions with students and parents. There was a common agreement among the focus group that when interacting with parents and students, teachers in these disadvantaged areas encounter unique challenges related to ethnic minority customs and cultures. Unlike the parents in urban areas who are often involved in their children's learning (Department of Social Services, 2015), the parents in the present study showed little concern about their children's study, leading to high student dropout rates and low class engagement. This was exemplified in extracts from a focus group interview in which two participants described the parents of their students as being "indifferent", "uncaring" and "neglecting" towards the students' learning (PFG3). One of the teachers further emphasized that the ethnic parents "delegated almost all of the responsibilities of taking care of the children to teachers" (PFG4). Other members in the group expressed their agreement with this point by giving a thumbs up. These finding echoes those of other studies acknowledging that interactions with students and parents are common stressors for teachers (Chang, 2009; Howard & Johnson, 2004). Although teachers may empathize with the parents being uninvolved in student learning, it is inevitable for them to be overwhelmed and frustrated with the parents' low involvement (Ellison & Woods, 2020). Indeed, teachers' job satisfaction and commitment, which are linked to resilience (Gu & Day, 2013), can be associated with parental support and collaboration (Allensworth et al., 2009).

Challenges when working with students include ethnic minority customs and cultures such as child marriage and patriarchy. These also significantly contributed to "high student dropout rates" (PFG7) where "female students are forced to stay at home to help the family...the boys here have more educational opportunities" (PFG4). Another participant, discussing these issues, expressed great concern about students' suicidal ideation and attempted suicides: "Ethnic minority students had incidents of eating 'la ngon' (poisonous leaves in the woods) to take their own lives" (PFG8). There is, in fact, among some Vietnamese ethnic groups a prevalent custom of eating "la ngon" (poisonous leaves) to commit suicide (UNICEF, 2018). This alarming situation notably adds more stress for teachers in this context.

Furthermore, language barriers and students' illiteracy, which are also typical obstacles in remote schools, have brought more difficulties to teaching: "in daily communication, they used their ethnic dialect, not the Kinh – the official Vietnamese language we speak" (PFG3, 7); and "too many students had problems with spelling and literacy" (PFG6, 9). Moreover, Vietnamese teachers generally become highly involved in students' academic and non-academic lives (T. M. H. Nguyen & Hall, 2017). Especially in remote areas, due to a critical lack of human resources, teachers have to do more non-teaching tasks of taking care of the students than teachers in other areas (Lock et al., 2012). Supporting this opinion, a teacher in another focus group said, "we have to help with cooking for the students and take turns to tutor them" (PFG 7). Since the students in disadvantaged areas are more likely to lack proper parental care, it is often up to the teachers to provide them support (Ellison & Woods, 2020).

Lack of social and institutional support and professional development opportunities

Resilience is a multi-faceted construct reflecting a dynamic process wherein personal and contextual factors come together (C. Mansfield et al., 2014; Ungar, 2012). In this process, protective contextual factors such as social and professional support are crucial to teachers' sense of commitment and resilience (Gu, 2014). Unfortunately, there was a lack of these factors for the teachers in our study. There was an agreement in most of the focus groups that the teachers had concerns about the remoteness from friends and family: "To maintain their teaching position, some teachers had to sacrifice by living far away from their friends and family members, even their small children" (PFG1). Furthermore, they also reported no practical support such as

allowances or rental subsidies from their schools. As one of the participants commented, “My salary is insufficient to pay the bills” (PFG1). Furthermore, teachers are responsible for covering their own rent if they wish to live near the school, as there is no subsidized accommodation (PFG9). Other members in this group said that they agreed with this point. Another teacher further indicated how hard it was to travel to work: “Visiting my family requires additional days off from work due to the long distance between my school and original home (400–500 km) without public transportation” (PFG8).

School support was, indeed, short term and only available when the teachers asked for it (e.g., “They don’t have any financial support, just emotional support sometimes” (PFG3)). Moreover, the teachers received insufficient professional development opportunities, with many of them having “never participated in any professional development programs” (PFG4, 5, 6) or the ones they managed to join were “unsatisfactory” (PFG4, 8, 10). Quality mentoring and professional development, in terms of formal organizational support, are resilience-enhancing (Ingersoll & Strong, 2011). In addition, workload reduction and opportunity to observe other teachers are also helpful (Papatraianou & le Cornu, 2014). Nevertheless, in the present study, these kinds of support were not available to the teachers who needed them the most. Since resilience occurs as a collective response to crises (Beltman, 2020), the lack of social and institutional support and professional development opportunities in this case warrants future interventions for these aspects. This finding echoes the identified need for institutional support in building teacher resilience building (Beltman et al., 2011; Gu, 2014; C. F. Mansfield et al., 2016). It also confirms previous studies in revealing that the teachers did not receive “visible and continued practical support” (Beltman et al., 2011, p. 192) from their schools and leaders.

From the teachers’ responses, the demands they faced clearly outweighed the available resources for coping, resulting in them feeling “stressful and exhausted” (PFG4, 5). However, echoing findings from Sullivan and Johnson (2012), their schools appeared to rely on teachers’ personal resilience to cope, which is insufficient.

Overall, Sections 3.1.1. to 3.1.3. present the following findings in response to Research Question 1. Firstly, insufficient infrastructural provisions in remote areas have intensified the difficulties faced by teachers, thereby potentially impeding their resilience. Moreover, challenges related to ethnic minority customs, cultural disparities and language barriers have further compounded the obstacles encountered by the participants. The teachers have also experienced an escalation in non-teaching responsibilities and after-hours duties due to parental neglect and over-delegation. In addition, the findings reveal limited social and institutional support or opportunities for professional development. These findings echo a recent study on the subject of online flipped learning by Lo (2023) using the RAISE design framework, encompassing five aspects, Resources, Activity, Institutional facilitation, Support, and Evaluation, which addresses challenges such as those identified in the present study. Challenges identified above also reflect several challenges faced by teachers in remote, high-poverty, or rural areas in the USA (Ellison & Woods, 2020) and Australia (Lock et al., 2012; Sullivan & Johnson, 2012; Downes and Roberts (2018).

Research question 2: what resilience strategies do they employ?

The teachers’ resilience strategies in this study are analysed and grouped into the four dimensions of the C. F. Mansfield et al. (2012) framework: Motivational, Professional, Emotional, and Social. The findings show that teachers’ motivational, professional and social resilience strategies are closely linked. In addition, the contextual challenges discussed above significantly shaped strategies the teachers used, and cultural influences played a role in how teachers employed them. There was a crucial lack of sufficient emotional strategies and institutional support, and thus the teachers mostly relied on personal resources to cope with the rigours of teaching in these remote, mountainous areas. The findings are discussed as follows in relation to the main elements of the four-dimensional framework.

Motivational strategies

Of all the four dimensions, motivational strategies were employed the most among the participating teachers. Among various aspects of the motivational dimension, “maintaining motivation and enthusiasm” and “self-challenges” came across as the main responses.

Maintaining motivation and enthusiasm: teaching passion. Motivation and passion were usually used interchangeably in the focus group discussions with the teachers. In two groups, the teachers said that passion drove their motivation: “I take passion as something to motivate me to stay with the job” (PFG3). For that reason, teaching passion is put in the category of maintaining motivation and enthusiasm. All teachers expressed a passion for teaching: “Had it not been for my passion, I would not have chosen this profession” (PFG 1, 5); and “It takes tremendous passion to work as a teacher of ethnic minority groups” (PFG6). One teacher even emphasized: “Without a genuine love for teaching, a teacher working with ethnic minority groups in remote areas could not survive” (PFG4). The rest of the group showed their agreement with this point by nodding their heads.

These responses show that the teachers appeared to have an intrinsic motivation, which is doing something simply for the enjoyment of it (Anderman & Dawson, 2010). They explained that maintaining enthusiasm and motivation is the source of their resilience at work: “Becoming a teacher is my lifelong pursuit. I believe that this true passion inspires me to overcome different kinds of challenges” (PFG6).

The teachers observed that teaching passion drove their intrinsic motivation which is a widely acknowledged personal resource to demonstrate resilience (C. F. Mansfield et al., 2016). Indeed, followed by self-efficacy, intrinsic motivation is the most prevalent personal source of resilience (Howard & Johnson, 2004; le Cornu, 2009). Teachers’ motivation is explored further in the next section on self-challenges which enhanced teaching self-efficacy.

Self-challenges. Interestingly, the participants viewed their poor working conditions as an opportunity for self-development. This perception reflects the reciprocal interactions between individuals and their environment in the resilience process (C. Mansfield et al., 2014), in which it is important to examine the way teachers interpret their circumstances (Hong, 2012). Instead of taking things personally, the teachers regarded their contextual issues as opportunities to rise above themselves, for example: “resilient teachers know how to build themselves up . . . if things were going smoothly, I don’t think that I could manage the challenges and chose this region to settle down” (PFG8); and “I felt more confident and prouder of overcoming myself” (PFG6). Other teachers in other focus groups highlighted that failures and hardship taught them “useful lessons for personal growth” (PFG5, 6). Trying to overcome and learn from the challenges, in turn, enhanced the teachers’ self-efficacy, one of the key components of resilience (Beltman et al., 2011).

Challenging working conditions appeared to boost the teachers’ resilience, which is somewhat in line with one interesting characteristic of resilience: it only manifests itself when an individual is faced with “a significant threat to their development” (Doney, 2013, p. 660). In addition, their perseverance could partly be explained by the cultural influences on Vietnamese teachers, one of which is Confucian teachings. Such teachings highly appreciate effort and persistence as coping mechanisms in times of adversity (He et al., 2010). However, it is worth noting that the Confucian influence could hinder teachers’ willingness to be adaptive and flexible during a crisis such as the COVID-19 pandemic. Dinh and Dao (2022) argue that a coping strategy Vietnamese teachers wanted to adopt during the pandemic period was control and organized instruction in front of students. This somewhat reflects a Confucian influence on Asian teachers in being authority figures to students (Park & Kim, 2008).

Professional strategies

In the C. F. Mansfield et al. (2012) framework, the professional dimension includes aspects such as flexibility, commitment to students, organizational skills and effective teaching skills. However, the

findings from the present study mostly identify “strong commitment to students” or “love for students” as resilience strategies adopted by the participants. This indicates insufficient job-related strategies contributing to teachers’ resilience, as one teacher recalls: “All this hard work takes up all day, so we don’t have any time left to invest in improving our knowledge and skills” (PFG8).

The teachers in most focus group discussions expressed strong affection for their ethnic minority students, considering them family members or adoring their innocence (PFG8, PFG5). The teachers were willing to provide care by “looking after them” (PFG7), “taking them to the hospital if they were sick” (PFG8), “washing their clothes” (PFG5) or “giving money to poor children” (PFG8). It is important to consider the cultural context of this study in which teachers are usually involved in students’ academic and non-academic lives (T. M. H. Nguyen & Hall, 2017). These teachers may appear to have crossed professional boundaries, yet their behaviours are considered culturally appropriate in Vietnam. We categorized “strong love for students” as a professional strategy based on interview responses that intertwined affection and commitment when describing dedication to student. The participants explicitly connected emotional bonds with professional diligence in supporting learners. Although “love” may not conventionally denote a strategic attribute, we preserved the emic linkage teachers conveyed between caring attachment and devoted practice. Across linguistic divides, connotations differ but representing participants’ voices remains paramount. Thus, we retained the phrasing despite potential dissonance with Western frameworks.

Furthermore, for the teachers, this dedication to students’ learning came from not only their connection with the students but also their own moral values and ethics in making contributions to improving literacy levels among the ethnic community. One teacher (PFG3) initially planned to quit but decided to stay and contribute to illiteracy reduction in the region. A sense of moral purpose and ethical value provides strength enabling teachers to be resilient (Gu & Day, 2013) and helps to buffer against burnout (Howard & Johnson, 2004; le Cornu, 2013). The purpose of making a change in ethnic students’ lives, along with a strong team spirit, thus encouraged the teachers to remain there. One teacher remarked, “If one person wants to quit, others may want to follow. Living in such a difficult place, we have to be strong to teach the students” (PFG1). What was clear from all groups was that the teachers were very mindful of the consequences of quitting, as they knew that their behaviour could affect fellow teachers. This awareness helped the teachers to strengthen their bonds with colleagues, which is discussed in the next section.

Social strategies

The Social Dimension of the framework captures aspects such as help-seeking and building support which were exhibited by the participating teachers. The development of social resilience strategies is closely linked to contextual challenges. As most teachers in the study lived far away from their original home in difficult conditions, they usually considered the ethnic community, their students, and their colleagues as their second family. This makes sense since relationships with the students and colleagues have significant impacts on teacher resilience (le Cornu, 2013; Papatraianou & le Cornu, 2014).

Seeking help and taking advice. Support from colleagues is a valuable contextual source of resilience (Beltman et al., 2011; le Cornu, 2013; C. F. Mansfield et al., 2016). What stood out from the interviews were strong team spirit and bonds among the teachers. The teachers had a clear sense of shared values and responsibilities, which are key facilitating factors for teacher collaboration (Vangrieken et al., 2015). In addition, the teachers actively sought help from school leaders and built collegial support:

As all of us were away from family, we always helped each other out (PFG1); I’m a novice teacher and sometimes I have problems dealing with students. The tips experienced teachers gave me worked very well. (PFG2)

One teacher even emphasized, “Had it not been for my colleagues, I wouldn’t have done much” (PFG4). It was clear from the responses that positive collegial relationships were vital to the

teachers' lives, given their tough working conditions. These relationships fostered not only a sense of belonging and relatedness but also professional commitment. One teacher narrated, "Seeing other people stay makes us want to stay" (PFG8). This quote is echoed in many others on the same topic, of the positive relationships with colleagues. The benefits of collegial support that the teachers experienced are broadly consistent with findings in other studies suggesting that colleagues can inspire an optimistic outlook (Jarzabkowski, 2022) and enhance morale (Howard & Johnson, 2004).

Building support and relationships with family and community. Family support, including emotional and practical support, can have a positive effect on teachers' resilience (le Cornu, 2013), as well as their commitment and ability to cope with challenges (C. Mansfield et al., 2014; Papatraianou & le Cornu, 2014). Teachers in the present study did not report facing family-related constraints such as balancing family and work, or pressure to quit teaching, strengthening the claims from previous studies that counted family as one source of support for teachers (Beltman et al., 2011; C. F. Mansfield et al., 2012). Most of the teachers said that they instead built and received strong family support (e.g., "My partner, parents and in-laws help me a lot with the housework and children" (PFG1, 3, 7)). However, while relationships with family and friends are significant for early-career teacher resilience (Castro et al., 2010; Johnson et al., 2014; le Cornu, 2013), the lack of Internet access made it hard for teachers to connect with their friends remotely. Alternatively, they learned to develop connections with the local ethnic community:

When we don't have classes, we often go to the villages to visit local people to build a good rapport with them" (PFG1); "During Lunar New Year holidays, I would go to their house to celebrate together". (PFG8)

Collectivism could also explain the teachers' endorsement of seeking help and building support networks. Besides Confucianism, collectivism is another cultural influence in Vietnam which emphasizes the importance of communal support and interpersonal relationships (Triandis, 2001). The teachers' efforts were reciprocated by the local people, as the teachers often noted that ethnic group people were "hospitable", "caring" and "empathetic" (PFG1, 8, 9). Two teachers (PFG8) shared similar experiences:

Whenever we went back to school from holidays, we were welcomed with a small party; The local people often greet me whenever they see me. I feel cared for and appreciated.

Emotional strategies

Educational research has consistently found that teaching is an emotionally charged profession (Gu, 2014; Hong, 2012; Zembylas, 2011). For that reason, developing emotional resources is one of the crucial elements that facilitate teacher resilience (le Cornu, 2009; C. F. Mansfield et al., 2016; Papatraianou & le Cornu, 2014). Emotional strategies include several skills such as emotional awareness and regulation (C. F. Mansfield et al., 2016), stress management and adaptivity (Beltman et al., 2011; C. F. Mansfield et al., 2012), attribution beliefs and responses to burnout (Hong, 2012), and seeking "rejuvenation and renewal" (Castro et al., 2010, p. 622).

However, in the present study, the teachers neither reported any of the strategies above when asked "what keeps you resilient?", nor did they receive any emotional support. They gave vague answers such as "I try to toughen up and keep a high spirit" (PFG6), "sometimes fellow teachers cheer us up" (PFG3) without further elaboration. The teachers did not talk about common emotional strategies such as self-care, a sense of humour, or seeking rejuvenation, which are argued by Castro et al. (2010) to be the most crucial ones. Their responses showed a substantial lack of the ongoing emotional practices that are important to resilience building (le Cornu, 2009). In addition, it is important to consider the study's cultural context. East Asians, including Vietnamese, value emotional restraint (Nam et al., 2018) to fit in with others (Triandis, 2001). In collectivistic cultures, people adjust their behaviour to others, motivating emotional suppression (Butler et al., 2007). These

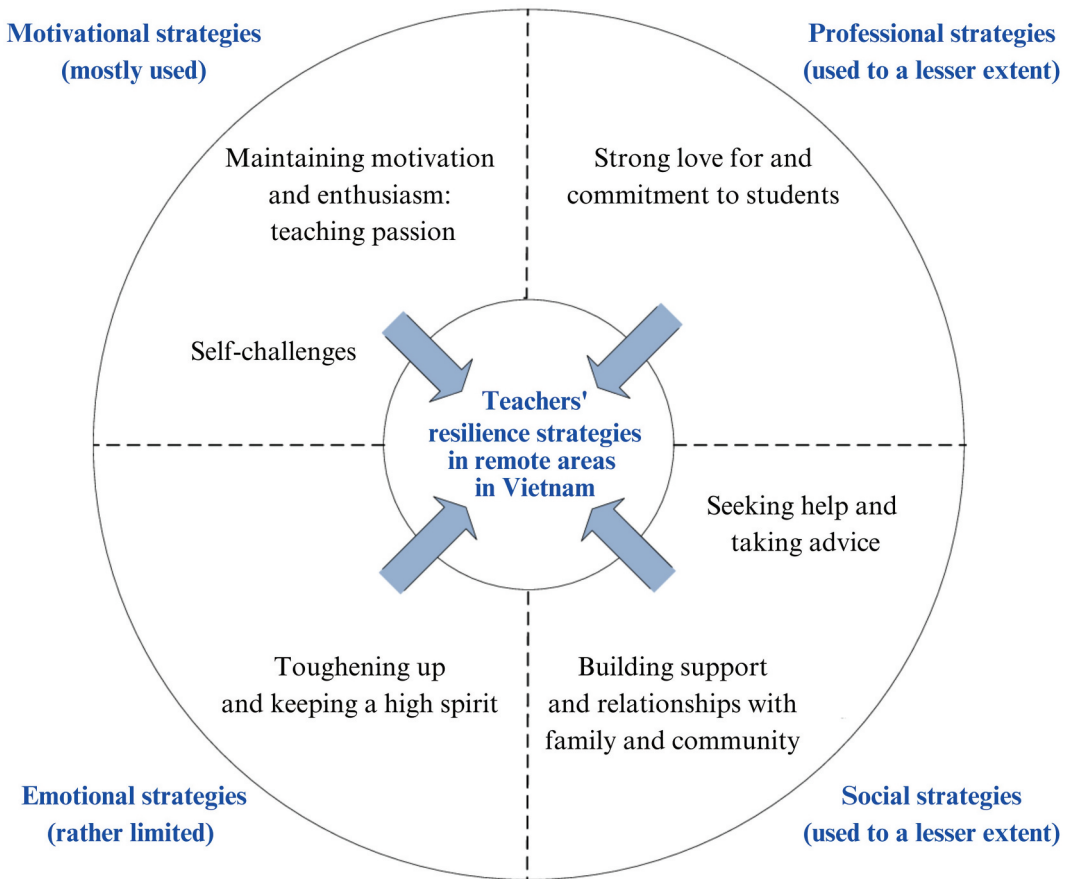


Figure 1. Teacher resilience strategies in remote areas in Vietnam (after Mansfield et al.'s (2012) model).

influences make teachers hesitant to discuss emotions and care for their emotional well-being, potentially leading to physical and emotional exhaustion.

In brief, significant disparities were identified in the strategies employed by participating teachers across the four dimensions: motivational, social, professional, and emotional (see Figure 1). While Mansfield et al.'s (2012) four-dimensional framework of teacher resilience provided a useful lens for analysing the strategies employed by teachers in this study, our findings reveal some gaps in alignment. Most notably, there was a lack of emotional resilience strategies reported by the teachers compared to the other dimensions in the framework. Teachers did not discuss common practices like self-care, humour, or renewal that typically facilitate emotional resilience (Castro et al., 2010). This indicates the framework may not fully capture the cultural restraints on emotional expression in Asian contexts, where suppressing feelings to conform to social norms is valued (Butler et al., 2007). Our study highlights the need to expand resilience frameworks to incorporate contextual and cultural influences. We propose that Mansfield's model could be adapted by elaborating the emotional dimension to account for cultures that emphasize emotional self-control versus emotional awareness. In addition, incorporating external factors such as infrastructure limitations may enhance the framework's transferability across vastly different regional contexts. Our research underscores the theoretical contribution of revealing gaps in existing understanding of teacher resilience strategies formed primarily in Western settings. We provide direction for developing more culturally sensitive conceptualizations to further research in Asian and other non-Western cultural environments.

Conclusions and implications

In conclusion, the findings of this qualitative paper suggest that teachers in northern mountainous areas of Vietnam experienced tremendous ongoing and unique challenges. The teaching context and Vietnamese cultural influence play a crucial role in shaping the teachers' resilience strategies. Their strategies mainly revolve around their own determination, motivation, family, and collegial support, which were the only available resources for them to stay and survive, but not yet thrive. There was a crucial lack of sufficient infrastructure and support from schools, as well as from the broader management system.

The findings indicate a significant need in remote areas for infrastructure improvement such as roads, classroom quality, water, electricity, and Internet access. Sufficient working conditions would enable teachers in high need areas to focus more on their teaching. For example, "visible and continued practical support" (Beltman et al., 2011, p. 192) such as funding, teacher housing, and transport assistance, as well as adequate resources and equipment, could facilitate resilience (Ellison & Woods, 2020). Since the schools in the present study relied heavily on the teachers' personal resilience to cope with various challenges, more institutional support should be implemented; both formal support (e.g., mentoring and professional development opportunities) and informal support (e.g., school leader and administrative staff support, collaboration with colleagues, positive school culture) at school. These supports are crucial, as they are resilience-enhancing (Papatraianou & le Cornu, 2014).

As resilience is one of the critical qualities for the good functioning of teacher education in the Asia-Pacific region (Zhu & Li, 2020), our study also shows various aspects to incorporate into intervention and teacher education programs for increasing teacher resilience and retention, as well as in preparing pre-service teachers for the rigorous reality of teaching in remote areas. For instance, the BRITE (Building Resilience in Teacher Education) framework (C. F. Mansfield, 2020) could be used online for both in-service and pre-service teachers, as it approaches aspects of resilience comprehensively, addressing relationships, motivations, well-being, and emotions (C. F. Mansfield, 2020). Following the present study's findings, since teachers employed affective strategies quite often when there was limited external support, they would benefit significantly from emotional skills training such as relaxation, mindfulness, stress management or cognitive reframing, and in building healthy relationships (C. F. Mansfield et al., 2016). In addition, the active use of protective strategies such as help-seeking, support, professional reflection and active learning should also be introduced into teacher education programs. These strategies help with developing resilience skills over time and coping with adverse conditions (Beltman et al., 2011; Castro et al., 2010; C. F. Mansfield et al., 2016; Sheridan et al., 2022). The present study's implications thus can inform policymakers to better support teachers in remote areas, in Vietnam and in similar regions around the world.

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